

Following the **Polysemy Example Curation References** style and the Golden Manual's rule to search broadly but split meanings conservatively, I would curate **former** as follows. The key is not to split *former neighbour / former president / former employee* into separate senses, because they all share the same underlying concept.

Word family: **former / formerly**

Base word: former

Related form: formerly

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / noun-like substitute in **the former** (在 *the former* 中作代稱用法)

Your sentence:

> “One person I find genuinely interesting is my **former neighbour**, Mr. Wong, who is a retired radio journalist in his late sixties.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **former** means that Mr. Wong **used to be the speaker's neighbour, but is no longer their neighbour now**.

It describes a **previous role, relationship, position, status, or identity that is no longer current**.

繁體中文： **以前曾經是某種身分、角色或關係，但現在已經不再是**

中文翻譯：

> “One person I find genuinely interesting is my **former neighbour**, Mr. Wong...”

「有一位我真心覺得很有趣的人，就是我**以前的鄰居 / 前鄰居**黃先生……」

Here:

former neighbour = 以前曾經是自己的鄰居，但現在已經不是鄰居的人

1. **former + role/person/status (身分 / 職位 / 關係) — 以前的；前任的；曾經是……的**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Describes a person, position, relationship, status, organization, place, etc. that **existed or applied in the past but no longer does now**.

Practice 1 — Original

> “One person I find genuinely interesting is my **former neighbour**, Mr. Wong.”

「有一位我真心覺得很有趣的人，就是我**以前的鄰居 / 前鄰居**黃先生。」

Practice 2

> “She had lunch with a **former colleague** from her old company.”

「她和以前公司的一位**前同事 / 以前的同事**一起吃午飯。」

Practice 3

> “The **former president** still appears regularly at public events.”

「這位**前總統 / 前任總統**仍然經常出席公開活動。」

former + noun = 某人或某事物以前具有某種身分、角色、關係或狀態，但現在已不再如此

Common examples:

* **former neighbour** = 以前的鄰居

* **former colleague** = 前同事

* **former student** = 以前的學生

* **former employee** = 前僱員

* **former manager** = 前經理

* **former president** = 前任總統

* **former owner** = 前任擁有人

* **former champion** = 前冠軍 / 曾經的冠軍

These are **not separate meanings** of **former**. The following noun changes, but the underlying semantic idea remains the same.

2. **the former** (前面提到的兩者中的第一個) — 前者

This is a genuinely different use.

When **two people or things have just been mentioned**, **the former** refers to **the first one**.

Practice 4

> “We could travel by train or by bus, but I prefer **the former**.”

「我們可以乘火車或巴士去，但我比較喜歡**前者**。」

Here:

****the former = train****

Practice 5

> “Both history and literature interest him, although ****the former**** is his main subject.”

「歷史和文學他都有興趣，不過****前者****才是他的主修科目。」

Here:

****the former = history****

****the former = 在剛才提到的兩個人、事物或選項之中，指第一個****

This meaning is not about somebody's ****previous status****.

Compare:

> “my ****former neighbour****”

= 我以前的鄰居

but:

> “tea and coffee; I prefer ****the former****”

= 茶和咖啡；我較喜歡****前者****

These require two different mental concepts, so they deserve separate entries under the Golden Manual.

3. ****formerly (以前；從前) — 過去曾經；以前****

****Formerly**** is the main useful related form.

It describes something that ****was true, existed, had a particular name, or had a particular function in the past, but is no longer the case now****.

Practice 6

> “The building was ****formerly**** a hotel.”

「這座建築**以前曾經**是一間酒店。」

Practice 7

> “She was **formerly** the head of the department.”

「她**以前曾經**是這個部門的主管。」

formerly = 在較早的時期曾經如此，但現在情況已經不同

Compare:

> “He is a **former teacher**.”

「他以前是一名教師。」

> “He **formerly worked as** a teacher.”

「他以前曾經當教師。」

The basic past-versus-present idea is the same, but the grammar differs:

* **former** = adjective, normally before a noun

* **formerly** = adverb, modifies a verb, adjective, clause, etc.

Important distinction: **former vs previous**

These words overlap, but they are not always interchangeable.

former

Usually emphasizes:

> **it was true in the past, but is no longer true now**

> “my **former neighbour**”

= 那個人以前是我的鄰居，但現在不是。

previous

Usually emphasizes:

> **something came before the current or later one in a sequence**

> “the **previous owner** of the house”

= 房子的上一任擁有人。

> “the **previous chapter**”

= 上一章。

So:

former = 強調以前具有某種身分 / 關係 / 狀態，但現在已不再具有

previous = 強調在時間或次序上位於目前 / 後來事物之前

For people and roles, they can overlap:

> **former president**

> **previous president**

Both can refer to somebody who held the office earlier, but **former president** primarily identifies that person's **past status**, while **previous president** more naturally identifies the person who came **before the present or subsequent president in sequence**.

Important distinction: **former** vs **ex-**

They frequently overlap when talking about people and relationships.

former

Neutral and broadly usable:

> **former colleague**

> **former employer**

> **former president**

ex-

Means a person who **used to hold a particular role or relationship**.

> **ex-president**

> **ex-boss**

> **ex-husband**

However, **ex** used by itself very commonly refers to a **former romantic partner**:

> “I met my **ex** yesterday.”

「我昨天遇到我的**前度 / 前任伴侶**。」

Former generally sounds more neutral and is especially natural with professional positions and formal roles.

Also, **ex-** cannot freely replace **former** everywhere:

> **former name** 

> **ex-name** 

> **former headquarters** 

> **ex-headquarters** usually unnatural

So the two are related but not universally interchangeable.

Important distinction: **former** vs **old**

former

Explicitly tells us that the relationship or status **no longer applies**.

> “a **former colleague**”

= 以前是同事，現在已經不是。

old

Can mean **from the past**, but it does not necessarily tell us that the relationship has ended.

> “an **old friend**”

usually means:

認識了很久的朋友 / 多年的老朋友

It does **not** normally mean:

以前是朋友、現在已不是朋友

Therefore:

> **former friend**

= 以前是朋友，但現在不再是

> **old friend**

= 認識了很久的朋友

This is a particularly useful learner distinction.

Important distinction: **the former vs the latter**

These form a common pair.

If two things are mentioned:

> “I enjoy books and films, but I spend more time on **the former**.”

the former = books = 前者

> “I enjoy books and films, but I spend more time on **the latter**.”

the latter = films = 後者

So:

the former = 剛才提到的兩者中的第一個

the latter = 剛才提到的兩者中的第二個

For clarity, **former/latter** works best when there are exactly **two** clearly identifiable alternatives.

Usage note: **former** normally comes before a noun

In its “previous status” meaning, **former** is normally an attributive adjective:

> “a **former journalist**” ✓

> “his **former home**” ✓

> “a **former neighbour**” 

Normally not:

> “The journalist is former.” 

Instead:

> “He is a **former journalist**.”

or:

> “He **used to be** a journalist.”

This grammatical behaviour is useful because **former** does not function exactly like ordinary adjectives such as *happy*, *busy*, or *young*.

Usage note: **former** does not necessarily mean immediately previous

This is important.

> “a **former manager**”

means:

someone who was a manager in the past but is no longer one

It does **not necessarily** mean:

the person immediately before the current manager

There could have been several managers since then.

By contrast:

> “the **previous manager**”

often suggests the manager immediately before the present one, depending on context.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is fairly small.

former

Two important uses:

1. past but no longer current
2. **the former** = the first of two previously mentioned things

formerly

= previously; at an earlier time when the situation was different

Unlike many verbs and nouns, **former** does not have a large productive derivational family that would add substantial value for an ordinary learner. Under the Golden Manual, there is no reason to manufacture obscure relatives merely to make the family look larger. The SOP explicitly says that a genuinely small family should be acknowledged rather than artificially expanded.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
former + role/status/relationship	以前曾具有某種身分、角色、關係或狀態，但現在已經不再如此
the former	在剛才提到的兩個人、事物或選項之中，指第一個；前者
formerly	某件事情、身分、名稱或狀態在較早時期曾經如此，但現在已經不同；以前 / 從前

For your original sentence

> “One person I find genuinely interesting is my **former neighbour**, Mr. Wong, who is a retired radio journalist in his late sixties.”

The exact meaning is:

former = 以前曾經具有某種身分或關係，但現在已不再如此

More specifically:

former neighbour = 以前曾經是我的鄰居，但現在已經不是我的鄰居的人

So the natural meaning here is:

> **my former neighbour = 我以前的鄰居 / 我的前鄰居**

It does **not** mean **the former = 前者** in this sentence.